

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy Misuse risk: Low

## WHY IT WORKS

Unsolicited advice activates resistance — even good advice, given uninvited, is often rejected because the receiver's autonomy feels bypassed. Asking permission transforms the relationship from expert-to-recipient into collaborative peers.

## WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not withholding help — the advice stays on offer; it simply waits for a yes.
- Not a scripted formality — a permission question asked while you are already drawing breath to advise is not a question.
- It is treating the other person's autonomy as the doorway the advice must walk through.

## THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Being around them feels safe to think out loud — help arrives only when it has been asked for.

Principle: People act on advice they requested and resist advice they were handed, regardless of its quality.

### What you gain

- Advice that is actually acted on
- Conversations where people open up sooner
- Fewer defensive reactions to good ideas
- Relationships that feel respectful rather than supervised
- Less frustration when your advice is declined

### Why most people fail at it

- They ask permission and then advise anyway when the answer is no.
- They repeat unheeded advice, which converts it into pressure.
- The question is rhetorical — their tone has already started advising.
- They cannot tell venting from a request for solutions, so they solve by default.

## CORE FORMULA

**Ask if they want advice -> Wait for yes -> Give it once -> Stop**

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before giving advice, ask: 'Would it be useful to hear my view on that?' Wait for the answer. If yes, give your advice once and stop.

## BEST FOR

- Coaching or mentoring relationships
- Advising friends or family on personal matters
- Situations where your advice was not requested
- Any conversation where someone is processing a problem

## METHOD, STEP BY STEP

### 1. Ask — Ask if they want advice

Before the solution leaves your mouth, ask one genuine question about whether input is wanted. Make no and 'just listen' equally acceptable answers.

*Smuggled: 'Have you thought about maybe just calling him?'*

*Asked: 'I have a thought on this — want it, or shall I just listen?'*

## 2. Wait — Wait for a real yes

Let them answer fully and take the answer at face value. A hesitant or polite yes is worth checking before you proceed.

*Steamrolled: '...anyway, what I would do is call him first thing.'*

*Waited: 'No rush — if you would rather think it through alone, that works too.'*

## 3. Give — Give it once

Deliver the advice plainly, labelled as advice, in one or two sentences. One clean version beats three hedged ones.

*Hedged: 'I mean, it is just a thought, and I could be wrong, but possibly...'*

*Once: 'My advice: call him directly and say what happened. That is my whole view.'*

## 4. Stop — Stop and release

Hand the decision back and do not revisit the advice if it goes untaken. Advice repeated becomes pressure, and pressure gets resisted.

*Revisiting: 'So... did you ever try the thing I suggested?'*

*Released: 'It is your call from here — I am interested in whatever you decide.'*

### FIELD TIP

#### The question is only real if no is a fine answer.

Ask whether they want input and mean it — the pause after the question is where they decide whether you respect them. If a no would frustrate you, you were never asking; you were announcing.

*Situation: A friend is venting about a decision you think is obviously wrong.*

*Don't: 'Look, can I just say something? You need to call the bank today.'*

**Do: 'Do you want ideas on this, or do you mainly need to vent? Either is fine.'**

### PHRASE BANK

#### Ask Permission · Before advising

- "Would it be useful to hear my view on that?"
- "Do you want input, or do you want me to just listen?"
- "Are you looking for a suggestion or just thinking out loud?"
- "I have a thought — want to hear it?"
- "Should I weigh in or would you rather work through it yourself?"
- "Do you want advice, or do you want me to hold the space?"
- "Is this a moment where input would help, or a moment where you need to talk?"

#### Give Once and Stop · After they say yes

- "My view is X — that is it."
- "One thought: ..."
- "I will say it once: ..."
- "My honest read is X. Take it or leave it."
- "I do not want to repeat it — but my advice is..."

#### Quick Permission Asks · Low-key ways to check first

- "Want a thought on that?"
- "Open to a suggestion?"
- "Shall I weigh in?"
- "Want my read, or just an ear?"
- "Say the word if you want ideas."
- "I have a view when you want it."

#### Workplace Permission · Advising colleagues without overstepping

- "Would a recommendation from me be useful here, or is this one yours to work through?"
- "I have seen a version of this before — want the comparison?"
- "Do you want my input now, or once you have a draft?"
- "This is your call to make. Would an outside view help?"

- "Before I offer anything — what kind of input would actually be useful?"
- "I can share how I would approach it, if that helps rather than muddies."

### **Advice Repair · When you advised without asking**

- "I jumped straight to advice there — I should have asked first."
- "You wanted to be heard and I handed you a to-do list. Let me just listen."
- "Scrap the advice for a moment — tell me more about what is going on."
- "I have given you my view twice now. I will drop it — it is your decision."
- "I asked if you wanted input and then talked over your no. That was not fair."
- "Ignore my suggestion if it does not fit — you know this situation better than I do."

## **WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST**

1. Weak: Unsolicited advice immediately: 'What you need to do is...'  
Better: Can I share a thought?  
**Best: Do you want advice on that, or would you rather think it through yourself?**
2. Weak: Repeating advice they did not take  
Better: I know I said this before, but...  
**Best: Give advice once. If they do not take it, accept their choice.**
3. Weak: Framing advice as a question to smuggle it in: 'Have you thought about doing X?'  
Better: You might want to consider X.  
**Best: Direct advice clearly labelled as advice, given once, after asking permission.**

## **DECISION TREE**

### **If Someone tells you about a problem and you have a solution**

Ask if they want the advice before giving it.

*"I have a thought on that — would it help to hear it?"*

### **If They say no to advice**

Respect it. Do not give the advice anyway.

*"That is fine — I am here if you want to talk it through."*

### **If They say yes and you give advice**

Give it once. Do not repeat it if they do not take it.

*"My advice is X. I will leave it at that."*

### **If They keep coming back with the same problem and not taking your advice**

Do not repeat the same advice. Ask what they are actually looking for.

*"I notice we keep coming back to this — what would actually help right now?"*

## **SCENARIOS**

### **Friend venting about a problem you could easily solve**

Ask first whether they want input or just to be heard. — "I have an idea that might help — want to hear it, or would you rather I just listen?"

### **Junior colleague struggling with a task**

Check whether they want help or to work it out themselves. — "I can see you are working through this — do you want input, or would you rather get there yourself?"

### **Parent advising adult child**

Ask before advising, genuinely accept no. — "I have a view on this — do you want to hear it?"

### **You have already given advice they have not followed**

Do not repeat it. Ask what they need instead. — "I gave you my view on this last time — I will not repeat it. What are you looking for right now?"

## **WORKED EXAMPLE**

### Without the technique

You: Here's what you should do — call him directly and be clear about what happened.

Friend: (defensive) It's more complicated than that.

### With the technique

You: I have a thought on this — do you want advice or just someone to hear you out right now?

Friend: Advice would actually be helpful.

You: Call him directly and be clear about what happened.

## COMMON MISTAKES

### Asking permission, then ignoring the no

*Sounds like: 'Fair enough — but honestly, you really should just...'*

Better: 'Understood. I am here to listen, and the offer stands if you ever want it.'

### Advice disguised as a question

*Sounds like: 'Have you considered simply doing what I would do?'*

Better: 'I have actual advice on this if you want it — otherwise I will keep listening.'

### Repeating advice they did not take

*Sounds like: 'I will say it again, because I really do think...'*

Better: Say it once. If it was not taken the first time, the repetition will not be either.

### Solving when they wanted witnessing

*Sounds like: 'Easy — here is what you do. First...'*

Better: 'That sounds hard. Do you want ideas, or company while you think?'

### Taking the declined advice personally

*Sounds like: 'Fine, do not listen to me — why do you even ask?'*

Better: 'My advice was an offer, not an instruction — your call is the one that counts.'

## READING THE ROOM

### Signs it is working

- People actually hear the advice when they asked for it.
- Relationships feel more respectful and less managing.
- Your advice is taken more often when it was wanted.
- You do not feel frustrated when advice is not followed.

### Signs to adjust

- People start saying yes just to end the asking.
- You ask for permission but give the advice regardless.
- You repeat advice they have not taken under the guise of 'just checking in.'
- Permission feels performative rather than genuine.

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- In emergencies where there is no time for permission — give the critical information immediately.
- In professional contexts where giving advice is literally your role (consultant, doctor, manager giving direction).
- When the permission question itself would feel clinical or awkward in a close personal relationship.

## RECOVERY LINES

### Best line: 'I never actually asked whether you wanted input. Do you?'

- "I went straight into advice mode — let me rewind and just listen."
- "I never actually asked whether you wanted input. Do you?"
- "That was my second lap of the same advice. I will park it."
- "You said just listen, and I heard fix it. Starting again."
- "Take everything I just said as one option, not the answer."
- "The advice came from caring, not from doubting you — and I will still rein it in."

## TECHNIQUE CHAINS

### Vent-first chain

*Ask what they need -> listen fully -> ask permission -> give once*

Do you need solutions right now, or just a proper listen?

Go on — I am not going anywhere.

I do have one thought, whenever you are ready for it.

My advice is to put it in writing today. That is the whole of it.

### Mentoring chain

*Check their thinking -> offer the choice -> advise once -> hand it back*

Where have you got to with it so far?

Would input from me help, or would you rather run your own route?

I would start with the customer data, not the survey.

Your call from here — happy either way.

## RELATED TECHNIQUES

### TC019 — Autonomy Release

Autonomy Release is the closing move — once the advice is given, the decision is handed back whole.

### TC010 — Curiosity Question

Curiosity Question is what you offer instead when the answer to 'want advice?' is no.

### TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline keeps the advice to one clean telling instead of a re-argued case.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

### Day 1 — Notice the urge to advise

Notice every time today when you feel the urge to give advice. Do not give it yet — just notice.

### Day 2 — Ask first

In one conversation, ask if the person wants your advice before giving it.

### Day 3 — Accept no

If they say no, accept it genuinely. Do not give the advice anyway or hint at it.

### Day 4 — Give once

When you give advice, say it once and stop. Do not repeat it.

### Day 5 — The listening alternative

When they say they want to be heard rather than advised, practise just listening.

### Day 6 — Repeated advice audit

Notice any advice you have given more than once. Stop giving it. Ask what they actually need.

### Day 7 — Calibration

Was advice received better when asked for? Did accepting 'no' change the relationship? Did you repeat any advice?

## AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask if they wanted advice before giving it?
- Did I genuinely accept if they said no?
- Did I give the advice once and not repeat it?
- Did I avoid framing advice as questions?
- Did I resist the urge to give advice they had not asked for?
- Did people seem more receptive to advice when they had asked for it?
- Did I offer to just listen rather than advise when that was what was needed?